

Leadership Discussion — Adaptive Learning in Change Leadership

Quan Khuc — Machine Learning Fundamentals (AIML-500) — Workshop Two Leadership Discussion

1. Personal, Professional, or Academic Situation

One professional situation where adaptive learning could have improved the outcome of a change initiative was during my work on marketing analytics and content publishing tools at World Wide Technology. In one project, I helped instrument Amplitude analytics across wwt.com so the marketing team could better understand campaign attribution, UTM-tagged landing page activity, and user engagement. The change itself was valuable because it gave stakeholders more visibility into how campaigns were performing. However, like many technology-driven changes, the success of the initiative depended on more than simply adding analytics events or building dashboards. It also depended on how well the team learned from stakeholder feedback after the tool was introduced.

Looking back, an adaptive learning approach could have made the rollout stronger. Instead of treating the analytics implementation as a mostly fixed solution, the team could have treated it as a learning cycle: release a first version, observe how marketing users interpreted the dashboards, collect feedback on what metrics were confusing or missing, and adjust the tracking plan based on real usage. For example, content creators and campaign managers may not have needed every available data point. They may have needed a smaller set of clearer signals that helped them answer practical questions, such as which campaign brought in the most engaged visitors or which content drove follow-up actions.

Adaptive learning would also have helped with change leadership because different stakeholders often adjust at different speeds. Developers may focus on technical correctness, while marketing teams may focus on usability, decision-making, and trust in the data. A leader managing that change would need to monitor whether people were actually using the dashboards, whether the data was changing decisions, and whether the process was reducing or adding friction. If adoption was lower than expected, the right response would not be to assume the users were resistant. Instead, the leader should ask what the system was teaching the team: Were the dashboards too complex? Were the metrics misaligned with business goals? Did users need training or better documentation?

This connects directly to AI and machine learning integration. AI/ML systems are rarely perfect when first introduced. They improve through feedback, better data, and careful adjustment. Leaders need the same mindset. They must be willing to experiment, evaluate results, and revise the approach instead of forcing a static plan. In my experience, the most successful change initiatives are the ones where the team keeps learning after launch.

2. AI-Generated Hypothetical Change Scenario

AI tool disclosed: ChatGPT, accessed through Devin.

A hypothetical example would be a university implementing an AI-powered adaptive learning platform across several online courses. The goal is to personalize learning paths for students by recommending practice problems, videos, and review materials based on each student's performance. At first, the leadership team assumes the main challenge will be technical integration with the learning management system. They create a rollout plan, train faculty, and launch the platform in three pilot courses.

After the first few weeks, the results are mixed. Some students like the personalized recommendations, but others feel the system is making assumptions about them too quickly. A few faculty members are concerned that the AI is pushing students toward easier material instead of challenging them. The data also shows that students who are already doing well use the tool often, while students who need the most help are using it less.

An adaptive leader would not view this as a failed implementation. Instead, they would treat the feedback as new information and adjust the change strategy. The leader might organize short feedback sessions with students and faculty, review usage data by student group, and work with the vendor or internal technology team to refine how recommendations are generated. The team might also change the communication strategy so students understand that the AI tool is a support system, not a judgment of their ability.

This scenario shows why adaptive learning is important in change management. The leader has to learn alongside the system. The original plan may have been logical, but real-world adoption revealed issues that were not obvious during planning. By staying flexible, experimenting with adjustments, and continuously monitoring outcomes, the leader can improve both the technology and the human change process around it. In AI/ML integration, this type of leadership is especially important because the technology, the data, and the users' needs can all evolve over time.